quirky reasons too. Just count the number of the letters in our names—15 each in both. We valued all this a lot. We even shared the same secretary—Pawan Kumar—for several years, and it was a unique thing for two Bollywood stars. But such was our friendship.

Amitabh was *thoda* junior to me in Bollywood, but in terms of stardom, he reached much, much higher than me. Then the days of his superstardom arrived. We remained friends, having done several films together like *Shaan*, *Naseeb*, *Dostana* and *Kaala Patthar*. And I was supposed to do some of his movies—*Sholay*, *Deewar* to name a few. Similarly, I heard Amitabh wanted to do *Kalicharan*, but I did it eventually.

There were a bit of ups and downs in our relationship, and you can attribute those to the stupidity of our respective stardom and the free spirits of our youth, making a few people speculate about us—*Kaun bhari pad gaya Kaala Patthar mein* and *kaun chha gaya*. But I distinctly remember we always had pure warmth for each other.

There used to be a sweeping sense of pure awe the moment Amitabh entered the set. Though he was friendly, and one could hear peals of laughter in the makeup room, he always maintained his dignity. On the sets, I guess he preferred to be alone, perhaps to stay focused on the job at hand. Sometimes, he seemed a lonely man at the top. He often praised me for my ability to memorise long dialogues, and when I think of him, I always found him coming prepared from home. He would slip into the character in his car, or in the vanity van. His commitment to work was phenomenal. It still is.

I find him as one of the few in the film industry with exceptional command of the language. A very good orator, a learned man and a real intellectual. Though at times, some may find him artificial, he is natural and self-made, and his biggest forte, like me, has been his confidence and an unshakable belief in his abilities. We are friends, and will always remain the same. I hold him in high esteem. ■

***Sinha has been Bachchan's co-actor in films such as* Naseeb, Dostana *and* Kaala Patthar**
(As told to Amitabh Srivastava)

grew up on a healthy diet of Bachchan films. He wept for his hero at the end of *Muqaddar ka Sikandar*; he smiled when he couldn't get tickets to *Hum* in Gwalior...because it meant Bachchan had finally had a hit after a bad run; and he was "nervous as hell" when, as executive creative director of Leo Burnett, he sat in Bachchan's office in Janak to narrate the "*Koi sawal chhota nahin hota*" promotional campaign for *KBC*. His mother and her family, he notes, were more proud when they learned he was working with Bachchan than when he got into IIT Bombay. "A childlike curiosity keeps him going," adds Tiwary. "He approaches a 30-second commercial or a two-and-a-half-hour film with the same rigour."

Almost everyone who has worked with him credits Bachchan's long shelf-life to his discipline or "*anushaasan*", as his character in *Mohabbatein* would say. Leena Yadav, who directed him in *Teen Patti*, recalls how she'd tell the four newcomers in the film—which included Shraddha Kapoor—to seek inspiration from his sense of punctuality and preparedness. In the unlikely event

Four decades on, Bachchan's career has outlasted other thespian luminaries not just by the volume of his films but also the range of work

of him running late, he is known to message and inform the director directly and expects an acknowledgement, as Tiwary would learn one day. Then there's the humility. Nothing holds him back from setting aside years of experience and countless accolades to learn from new creators, regardless of their age. Filmmakers mention how he is totally open to retakes and suggestions. And yet, there's a dignified kind of gravitas. "*Ek thahraav bhi hai*," as Leena Yadav puts it. "He doesn't underline his own presence, but then you can't help not underline it. However humbly he is sitting there, he is Amitabh Bachchan."

THE MYTHICAL BEING

This aura, what R. Balki calls the "myth and mystique", also transmits itself to viewers. And that's why audiences cannot get enough of him. Balki, one of his most frequent

